

BRENDA ONG

Chief of Staff · Program & Business Operations · AI-Native Operating Systems

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SUMMARY

Chief-of-staff-style operator with 13+ years in program operations, business operations and startup operations across government, INTERPOL, frontier technology and an early-stage company. Builds the operating layer small teams run on: planning cadences, trackers, decision logs, escalation paths, onboarding systems and board-ready briefing materials. AI-native - prototypes lightweight internal tools with Claude Code, Codex and Python, cutting report preparation 30% and manual consolidation 66.7%. Manages a S\$65M+ portfolio with external funding awards and milestone-based disbursement tracking, raised on-time milestone delivery 74% to 90%, and holds sensitive candidate, board and national-security context with discretion. MIT Sloan Fellows MBA.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Chief of Staff · Program Operations · Business Operations · Special Projects · Project Management · Startup Operations · Research Operations · Operating Cadence & Planning Rhythms · Trackers & Source-of-Truth Systems · Decision Logs & Follow-Up Systems · Board & Leadership Materials · Executive Briefings · Portfolio & Dependency Visibility · Blockers, Owners & Decision Dates · Grantmaking & Funding Operations · Diligence Coordination · Disbursement & Milestone Tracking · Finance & Legal Handoffs · Hiring Pipelines & Candidate Trackers · Onboarding & Context Systems · Advisor, Fellow & Collaborator Pipelines · Cross-Functional Coordination · AI Agents & Automation · Vibe Coding (Claude Code, Codex) · Google Workspace & Drive · Python, SQL, Tableau · AI Governance & Model Safety · Discretion with Sensitive Context

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

HOME TEAM SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY AGENCY (HTX) - SINGAPORE

Jul 2025 – Present

Principal Scientist, Disruptive Technologies Office (Operating Lead, Emerging-Technology Portfolio)

Own the planning, coordination and decision layer for a multi-workstream emerging-technology programme spanning AI, model safety, space and quantum, across frontline agencies, researchers, engineers and industry partners.

- Built an AI-assisted analyst workflow with Claude Code and Codex, cutting report preparation time 30%.
- Raised on-time milestone delivery from 74% to 90% across a S\$65M+ multi-year technology portfolio.
- Made external funding awards to research partners and tracked disbursement against milestones across the S\$65M+ portfolio.
- Ran readiness-review cadence with owners, risk registers and go/no-go criteria, closing ~90% of pre-launch findings.
- Prototyped two LLM tools - sentiment forecasting and a model behaviour-drift dashboard - evidencing leadership adoption decisions.
- Led 8 executive workshops with 40+ senior leaders, converting broad strategy into 6 funded, roadmapped opportunities.
- Established an operating model of ownership maps and escalation paths, adopted across 10 frontline agencies.
- Authored 7 leadership briefings translating a technology roadmap into board-level investment and adoption decisions.
- Coordinated handoffs across 10 technical and frontline teams, tracking dependencies and corrective actions through closure.
- Deployed 3 AI systems - a research agent, summarisation pipeline and auto-updating tracker - removing recurring team work.

LYMEALERT - BOSTON, MA

Jun 2023 – Present

Co-Founder, Chief Operating Officer & Chief Marketing Officer (Strategic Advisor since Jul 2025)

Built the operating foundation of a pre-seed diagnostics company from zero while completing the MIT Sloan Fellows MBA.

- Automated reporting and task-tracking across 5 workstreams, cutting manual consolidation 66.7% (~10 hours weekly).
- Produced investor materials, diligence responses and use-of-funds scenarios supporting US\$5M+ in financing.
- Raised milestone completion from 65% to 90% using weekly readiness reviews and dependency tracking.
- Built a pre-launch operating model across 6 workflow domains, defining owners, decision protocols and escalation handling.

SINGAPORE POLICE FORCE - SINGAPORE

2013 – 2023

Assistant Director, Public Communications (Trust, Safety & 24/7 Incident Operations)

Feb 2021 – May 2023

Directed a 28-person 24/7 function covering incident triage, online-harms enforcement, disinformation response and national spokesperson duties.

- Ran a 24/7 incident triage queue at 100+ cases daily, sustaining a 99% response SLA.
- Built a QA and calibration system reviewing 500+ decisions monthly, cutting hand-off failures 40% and overdue cases 45%.
- Cut misinformation mean-time-to-detection over 50% to three hours using social-listening and rules-based alerting.
- Ran screening, interview panels, candidate trackers and offer decisions with HR to build a 10-person unit.
- Managed and developed a 28-person team, sustaining employee engagement above 75% under sustained crisis load.
- Directed counter-narrative response to 20+ disinformation campaigns, supporting a 96% public trust rating.
- Enforced content policy across 5 platforms serving 1.3M+ users, routing child-safety and vulnerable-person cases to intervention.

Head of Operations, Tanglin Police Division**Aug 2019 – Feb 2021***Owned operations, resourcing and policy for a division of ~1,500 officers.*

- Reallocated 33% of a S\$10M annual resource pool to priority risks while holding 98% service performance.
- Stood up a 35-officer counterterrorism capability adopted across 7 divisions, cutting per-shift staffing 20%.
- Built the onboarding and runbook system for a new counterterrorism structure, onboarding 300+ officers.
- Ran a 10-exercise annual programme, lifting readiness scores 25% and closing 98% of after-action items on deadline.

Commanding Officer, Bukit Panjang Neighbourhood Police Centre**Jan 2018 – Aug 2019**

- Built a Python and Tableau crime-analytics model redesigning patrol deployment, cutting five major offences 30%.
- Raised employee engagement from 80% to 93% across an 88-officer command.
- Founded the force's first Women's Committee, a model subsequently adopted across the Singapore Police Force.
- Co-authored the AI ethics paper seeding Singapore's Advisory Council on the Ethical Use of AI and Data.

Deputy Team Leader, Crisis Negotiation Unit (concurrent)**Jul 2017 – May 2023**

- Stabilised 40+ threat-to-life incidents using structured de-escalation and decision thresholds still in use.

Operations Officer, Future Operations Division (founding 'skunkworks' unit)**Jan 2015 – Jan 2018**

- Cut duplicative systems 42.9% by programme-managing a 10-year joint technology masterplan across 10 departments.
- Centralised fragmented emergency call centres into a 24/7 Ops Command, improving response times 20% across 1M+ annual calls.
- Raised pilot-to-adoption conversion from 10% to 50% by adding stage gates, success measures and post-pilot ownership.
- Devised national cybersecurity and data-security policy for Singapore's National Digital Identity programme.

Investigation Officer, Central Police Division**Jun 2013 – Jun 2014**

- Solved 20+ investigations monthly at 85%+ solvability; built the case-tracking system and investigative rulebook.

INTERPOL GENERAL SECRETARIAT - LYON, FRANCE**Jun 2014 – Jan 2015****Executive, Strategic Planning Directorate**

- Prioritised, budgeted and tracked the full initiative portfolio of a 195-country organisation.
- Produced the Environmental Scan foresight series briefing senior leaders on 5–10 year law-enforcement risk.
- Staffed the Secretary-General with executive mission briefs across international engagements.
- Revised enterprise risk-management policy and drafted SOPs for risk reporting and monitoring.
- Tracked 25 funded initiatives from intake to decision date, holding ~80% to schedule.

EDUCATION**MBA, Sloan Fellows Program - MIT Sloan School of Management**

2024

*ASEAN Fellow · Specialisation in Business Analytics; coursework in AI & Machine Learning · GPA 4.9/5.0***MA, Security Studies - Georgetown University, School of Foreign Service**

2012

*Outstanding Academic Achievement · Concentration: International Security · GPA 3.89/4.0***BA (Hons, First Class), Politics, Psychology & Sociology - University of Cambridge**

2011

*Kerslake Scholar, Emmanuel College; Awarded Honorary MA in 2015***MTech in AI Systems (in progress) - National University of Singapore, ISS**

2026 – present

CERTIFICATIONS, SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Board & Leadership: Honorary Secretary (Board Member), POLWEL Cooperative Society (2022–present) - own agendas, board papers, minutes and follow-up actions across 4 board meetings annually · The Commendation Medal (COVID-19), Prime Minister's Office, Singapore (2023) · Singapore Government Overseas Scholarship

Certifications: AI Security, Lakera (2024) · Data Science Professional, DataCamp (2024) · AI Nanodegree, Heicoders (2023) · Certified ScrumMaster, Scrum Alliance (2023) · Google Analytics IQ (2023) · Google Data Analytics, Coursera (2022)

Tools & Technical: Claude Code · Codex · LLM prototyping & evaluation · Python · SQL · R · Tableau · Power BI · Google Workspace & Drive · Notion-style trackers · Workflow automation

Other Skills: Trained Crisis Negotiator · Media Spokesperson Training · Futures Methodologies

Languages: English (native) · Mandarin Chinese (native) · French (basic)